(a highly popular move) and channeled the remaining revenues into cleaning up and restoring the irrigation systems that made Sri Lanka fertile. (“In a country like this,” he is said to have remarked to his ministers, “not even the smallest bit of rain ought to be allowed to flow into the ocean without profiting man.”) Canals and causeways that had fallen into disrepair were cleaned out and rebricked. He ordered a small reservoir on the outskirts of the city enlarged and combined with other storage tanks, creating a massive new reservoir that became known as the Sea of Parakrama, and on an artificial island in its center he built a beautiful three-story palace that overlooked the new waters. Near the northern town of Mannar, he had an even larger reservoir built: the Giant’s Tank, an engineering feat that produced a massive artificial lake with completely man-made embankments on a sloping plain. The Giant’s Tank turned the dry, salty north of the island into an area so fertile that it is still known today as the Rice Bowl.[3]



*16.1 The Giant’s Tank.*
Credit: © 2009 Dhammika Heenpella / Images of Sri Lanka

None of this work was cheap, but the resulting crops balanced out the expense:

He drained great marshes and bogs, and made the water discharge itself